Managing resources at live music events

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Managing resources

1. Human resources

- This means managing people — including staff, volunteers, security teams, cleaners, and artist support workers
  - **Hiring temporary staff and volunteers**
    - Live events often need hundreds or even thousands of temporary workers. These may include ticket scanners, stewards, bar staff, and backstage crew
    - Volunteers are often given free tickets in return for their time. Charities like **Oxfam** run stewarding teams at events like *Latitude* and *WOMAD*
  - **Training in safety and customer service**
    - Staff must know how to help people in an emergency, deal with crowd control, and speak politely to customers
    - **Showsec** provides training for security staff working at events like *Wireless Festival* and *BBC Radio 1's Big Weekend*
  - **Example: Glastonbury Festival**
    - Glastonbury uses **over 30,000 staff and volunteers** to help manage everything from ticketing and security to recycling and artist management

2. Physical resources

- This includes all the equipment and materials needed to build and run the event.
  - **Staging, lighting, and sound**
    - Companies like **PRG** and **Stageco** provide huge custom-built stages, lighting rigs and sound systems
    - Smaller stages are often used for DJs, workshops or comedy acts
  - **Toilets, fencing, and accommodation**
    - Events need portable toilets, fencing to manage crowd movement, bins, hand-washing stations

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

using generators
    - **Example: Boomtown Festival**
        - Boomtown builds an entire **themed village** with film-style sets, stages, and props. It remains of the most complex physical builds in the UK festival scene

3. Financial resources

- This involves planning, budgeting, and managing money before, during, and after the event
    - **Budget planning**
        - Key costs include: artist fees, infrastructure (stages, toilets, fencing), security, staff wages, marketing, insurance and licences
        - Headline artists can charge **£100,000–£1 million+**, depending on their fame
    - **Income from tickets, sponsors, and extras**
        - Events earn money from ticket sales, VIP upgrades, parking, food and drink sales and sponsorship
        - Many festivals offer **tiered pricing** - where early bird tickets are cheaper and prices go up over time
    - **Example: Y Not Festival**
        - This small-to-medium UK festival uses **tiered ticket pricing** to help spread income across the year and manage cash flow

4. Information resources

- This includes software, data, and digital tools used to organise the event and keep things running smoothly
    - **Ticketing and artist schedules**
        - Systems like **Ticketmaster**, **Eventbrite**, or **Event Genius** track who's attending, when acts are performing and where staff are based
        - Artist riders (special requests for dressing rooms, etc.) are also tracked
    - **Communication and coordination**
        - Walkie-talkies, mobile phones, and **event apps** are used to share updates with staff and festivalgoers
        - Some events use live messaging systems for emergencies or weather warnings
    - **Example: Reading & Leeds Festivals**
        - They use a **mobile app** with real-time updates, stage times, interactive maps and notifications for schedule changes or weather issues

5. Risk and contingency management

- Festivals must prepare for things that could go wrong and have back-up plans ready
    - **Common risks**

Help me understand

performances
    - **Insurance and back-up suppliers**
        - Most events take out **event cancellation insurance** and have back-up suppliers for power, fencing or sound
        - Schedules often include **buffer times** in case of delays
    - **Example: Camp Bestival (2023)**
        - High winds damaged part of the main stage. Organisers had to **quickly rework the schedule**, moving performances to other areas and keeping fans informed

6. Sustainability and compliance

- Festivals must follow the law and try to reduce their impact on the environment
    - **Legal compliance**
        - This includes licences for music, alcohol sales, safety inspections and noise limits
    - **Eco-friendly actions**
        - Many events now offer **recycling points**, **compost toilets** and encourage **public transport** or **carbon offsetting**
        - Plastic bottle bans and reusable cups are now common
    - **Example: Green Man Festival**
        - This Welsh festival is known for its **low-waste policy**, **solar-powered areas** and local food sourcing. It has won awards for its environmental efforts

Case study: When things go right

- **Green Man Festival** is a four-day music and arts event held in the Brecon Beacons, Wales
- It attracts around 25,000 people each year and is praised for its peaceful atmosphere and focus on sustainability

Human resources	• Around **5,000 staff and volunteers** are hired each year, including stewards, bar staff and artist handlers
Physical resources	• The site includes 10+ music stages, camping areas, a children's zone and wellness spaces - all built on a greenfield site
Financial resources	• Green Man sells early bird tickets, weekend passes, and family packages • Sponsors and stallholder fees also support the budget
Information resources	• The official app provides maps, set times and eco-guides • Crew use digital walkie-talkies to stay in touch
Risk management	• The team prepares for weather disruptions and crowd safety issues, with trained first aiders and back-up plans in place
Sustainability	• The festival avoids plastic, runs food waste composting and encourages train travel with shuttle buses from the station • It has won multiple **A Greener Festival Awards**

Case study: When things go wrong

- **Boardmasters** is a popular five-day festival in Cornwall, UK, combining live music with surfing and beach events
- It normally attracts around 50,000 people and features top acts like Florence + The Machine and Foals

- While safety was the main reason, the cancellation exposed problems across several areas

Resource	Failure
Human resources	• Thousands of **temporary workers and volunteers** were already on site, including stage crew, bar staff and stewards ◦ Many had travelled long distances and had nowhere to stay after the cancellation. • Some staff claimed they were not informed directly and only found out through **social media or news reports** • Lack of clear internal communication left workers confused and caused distress
Physical resources	• **Strong winds and heavy rain** were forecast, and stages, tents, and fencing were already in place • Some **infrastructure was not yet fully secured**, and there were risks that tents and scaffolding could collapse or blow over, creating danger for staff and early arrivals • Power generators and temporary roads were already being installed, but heavy rainfall **threatened to flood parts of the site**
Financial resources	• The cancellation happened after most infrastructure had been built, meaning many **costs had already been paid** (e.g. artist deposits, logistics and staffing) • Refunds had to be issued for tens of thousands of tickets, **losing millions in revenue** • Food vendors and traders who had stocked up also **lost income**, with some reporting over **£5,000 in wasted supplies**
Information resources	• Fans complained that they only found out about the cancellation **via Twitter or Instagram** • The festival's **website and app crashed** due to high traffic • No clear **information system** was in place to handle customer questions, refunds, or travel plans, leading to confusion and frustration

	• Some questioned why there wasn't a **stronger backup plan** or clearer weather contingency • Emergency plans for things like artist rescheduling, staff redeployment, or communication breakdowns were not well executed
Sustainability and compliance	• Since the cancellation happened late, **large amounts of waste** (food, fuel, packaging) were left behind • Traders had already delivered food and drink, which then went unused and unrefrigerated • Local residents were left with traffic and environmental damage - **heavy vehicles had churned up the land**, and there were complaints about the lack of clean-up support

Lessons learned

- Boardmasters 2019 shows how even well-established festivals can face serious problems if risk planning and resource management are not strong enough
- In particular:
  - Events must have **clear communication** plans for staff and customers
  - **Contingency** plans should be tested in advance, especially for weather
  - **Information systems** need to be able to cope with emergencies and high demand.
  - Even if an event is cancelled, organisers must consider the **financial** and **environmental impact**

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